

Nominalisation

Part 1: Proofreading quiz

Each sentence contains TWO errors: one in an inversion structure and one in a relative clause. Proofread the sentences.

Not only online learning saves travelling time, but it also gives students access to courses which is not available in their own schools.
Rarely teenagers verify the truth of what they share online, which make them easy targets of scams.
Only by setting clear screen-time rules parents can protect their children, who often spends hours gaming late into the night.
Never the school has considered banning phones in class, which distracts students from every lesson.
Seldom victims of online scams report the fraud to the police, which make it harder to catch the criminals.

Teacher's answers

Item	Correction (fix both errors)
1	Not only does online learning save travelling time, but it also gives students access to courses which are not available in their own schools. (Add do before the subject; is → are — 'which' refers to courses.)
2	Rarely do teenagers verify the truth of what they share online, which makes them easy targets of scams. (Add do before the subject; make → makes — the clause refers to sharing without checking.)
3	Only by setting clear screen-time rules can parents protect their children, who often spend hours gaming late into the night. (Move can before parents — 'Only by' inverts subject and auxiliary; spends → spend — 'who' refers to children.)
4	Never has the school considered banning phones in class, which distract students from every lesson. (Move has before the school — 'Never' inverts; distracts → distract — 'which' refers to phones.)
5	Seldom do victims of online scams report the fraud to the police, which makes it harder to catch the criminals. (Add do before the subject; make → makes — the clause refers to the whole failure to report.)

Warm-up: From words to nouns

Write the noun form of each word. The last six words are more challenging.

Word	Noun
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decide	decision
improve	improvement
communicate	communication
introduce	introduction
regulate	regulation
protect	protection
explain	explanation
solve	solution
use	use
develop	development
aware	awareness
important	importance
depend	dependence
responsible	responsibility
choose	choice
know	knowledge
lose	loss
prove	proof
believe	belief
strong	strength

Part 2: Nominalisation in formal writing

Nominalisation names an action or a quality as a noun, so that ‘people use phones’ becomes ‘the use of phones’. It packs ideas into fewer words and gives formal writing a more academic tone, and it can also carry an idea from one sentence into the next. Together they are among the clearest signs of a higher band in DSE Paper 2.

Example 1: Verb → noun

Plain:	The school decided to introduce e-books, and students supported this.
More formal:	The school’s decision to introduce e-books won students’ support.

The school’s decision to introduce e-books won students’ support. The introduction of the new system also saved paper and lightened schoolbags, and teachers soon noticed a rise in reading time. Other schools could follow this example with little extra cost.

Example 2: Adjective → noun

Plain:	Students should be aware of online scams.
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More formal:	Students should show awareness of online scams.
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Students should show awareness of online scams. The danger is real and growing, yet many victims discover the fraud only after money has already been lost, which means the damage is done. A short lesson on spotting false messages would build this awareness early.

Example 3: Because-clause → noun phrase

Plain:	Because people share news very quickly, rumours spread fast.
More formal:	Owing to the rapid sharing of news, rumours spread quickly.

Owing to the rapid sharing of news, rumours spread quickly. A false story can reach thousands of people within minutes, and the difficulty of checking every update means that some readers forward it before anyone notices. Careful readers, therefore, pause and verify before sharing anything.

Example 4: If-clause → noun phrase

Plain:	If the school does not update its computers, online lessons will fail.
More formal:	Without updated computers, online lessons will fail.

Without updated computers, online lessons will fail. The school's plan to renew its equipment, however, has already won support from the Parent-Teacher Association, and teachers have promised to test the new system before the start of term.

Nominalisation as a linking device

Nominalisation can also link one sentence to the next: turn a verb or adjective into a noun and open the new sentence with it. Instead of the vague 'This is because... / This shows that...', use 'This...', 'Such...' or 'The ... of...' — the noun bridge says the same thing in fewer words and earns a higher band.

Plain (weak link):	Many young people click on links without checking where they lead. This is because they trust whatever looks official.
Nominalised (This / Such + noun):	Many young people click on links without checking where they lead. <i>Such misplaced trust</i> is exactly what scammers exploit.

Part 3: Practice sets

Rewrite each simple sentence using nominalisation. The sentences are about technology and communication, so keep the register formal. The later sets (4–7) are more challenging.

Example Set 1 (Verb → noun)

Simple sentence:	People use social media all the time, so they cannot concentrate on their studies.
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Prompt:	<i>Turn the verb ‘use’ into a noun: begin with ‘Students’ constant use of ...’.</i>
Teacher’s Answer:	Students’ constant use of social media weakens their concentration.

Example Set 2 (Adjective → noun)

Simple sentence:	Parents worry that young people are too dependent on their smartphones.
Prompt:	<i>Turn ‘dependent’ into a noun: begin with ‘Many parents worry about young people’s ...’.</i>
Teacher’s Answer:	Many parents worry about young people’s strong dependence on their smartphones.

Example Set 3 (Because-clause → noun phrase)

Simple sentence:	Because online games are so attractive, many teenagers neglect their homework.
Prompt:	<i>Replace the ‘Because ...’ clause with a phrase beginning ‘Owing to the ...’.</i>
Teacher’s Answer:	Owing to the strong appeal of online games, many teenagers neglect their homework.

Example Set 4 (Verb → noun)

Simple sentence:	The government will improve the security of online banking, which will protect customers.
Prompt:	<i>Turn ‘will improve’ into a noun and begin with ‘The improvement of ...’.</i>
Teacher’s Answer:	The improvement of online banking security will protect customers.

Example Set 5 (Adjective → noun)

Simple sentence:	Students are much more aware of online privacy than they were ten years ago.
Prompt:	<i>Turn ‘aware’ into a noun and rewrite the sentence without the verb ‘are’.</i>
Teacher’s Answer:	Students’ awareness of online privacy has grown sharply over the past decade.

Example Set 6 (If-clause → noun phrase)

Simple sentence:	If the government does not control social media companies more strictly, online scams will just keep growing.
Prompt:	<i>Replace the ‘If ...’ clause with a noun phrase beginning with ‘Without ...’.</i>
Teacher’s Answer:	Without stricter regulation of social media companies, online scams will continue to grow.

Example Set 7 (Linking: adjective → noun)

Simple sentence:	Young people rarely question what they read online. This is because they are too careless.
Prompt:	<i>Turn the adjective ‘careless’ into a noun and replace ‘This is because’ with a noun bridge opening ‘This...’ or ‘Such...’.</i>
Teacher’s Answer:	Few young people question what they read online. Such carelessness

	makes them easy prey for scammers.
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Part 4: Writing Task

Instructions:

1. Your school magazine is running a series called 'Life in the Digital Age'. Write ONE paragraph (about 80 words) explaining why online scams have become a common problem for young people, and suggesting ONE thing schools could do to protect them.
2. Nominalise ONE of the words in the word bank below and use the noun in your paragraph. Also add ONE relative clause or ONE inverted pattern (e.g. Not only ... but also ...; Never ...; Rarely ...).
3. Link your ideas: open at least ONE sentence with a nominalised noun phrase that refers back to the previous sentence (e.g. 'This + noun').

Word bank — turn ONE of these five into a noun, then use it in your paragraph:

protect → protection · aware → awareness · educate → education · responsible → responsibility
· believe → belief

Bank answers: protect → protection; aware → awareness; educate → education; responsible → responsibility; believe → belief. Note how Sample answer 2 uses 'awareness' and Sample answer 3 uses 'responsibility'.

Sample answer 1 (Verbs → nouns) Online scams have become a common problem because many young people trust official-looking messages without a second thought. This misplaced trust is easy to exploit: fake websites and phishing links catch even careful users by surprise. Schools, in my view, should teach students the importance of checking every message before clicking, which is a vital skill in the digital world. A short course on online safety could easily be added to existing computer lessons, and it would reach every student equally.

Sample answer 2 (Adjectives → nouns) Many students are unaware of how dangerous online scams are, and they trust strangers' messages far too easily. This lack of awareness becomes costly only after money or personal data has been stolen, which is usually far too late. Schools should therefore run regular lessons on spotting scams, treating it as a basic life skill rather than an optional topic. Knowing how to pause and double-check before paying is the strongest protection available to any student.

Sample answer 3 (Because / if → nouns) Owing to the constant flow of scam messages on social media, young people are targeted daily. This constant targeting is hard to escape; the ease of creating fake websites, together with the difficulty of telling them from real ones, leaves victims blind until it is too

late. The responsibility for protection must be shared, which means schools, platforms and parents have a part to play. Parents can talk about scams at home, while teachers can make online safety a regular topic. Each sample opens ONE sentence with a nominalised bridge: “This misplaced trust”, “This lack of awareness”, “This constant targeting” — point these out to students before they write.